Articles

ORDERING THE SENSATIONAL: SHERLOCK HOLMES AND THE FEMALE GOTHIC

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Sherlock Holmes, like other positivists of the nineteenth century, represents the world as causally ordered and rationally understandable: "life is a great chain, the nature of which is known whenever we are shown a single link of it" (*A Study in Scarlet* [Doyle 1:14]). In Holmes's system of deduction, control of this world is intimately linked with knowledge. As he remarks to Violet Hunter in "The Copper Beeches," a mystery "would cease to be a danger, if we could define it" (437).

As many critics have noted, however, the world that emerges in the Holmes stories does not completely fit with Holmes's rational philosophy. In "Dreams, Transformation, and Literature: The Implications of Detective Fiction," A. D. Hutter sees a "deeper irrationality" behind "the relentlessly logical process of ratiocination" in both Conan Doyle and Poe (191). Catherine Belsey, in *Critical Practice,* finds that the "silent women" who haunt many of the Holmes stories contradict the message that all aspects of the world can be controlled through definition (114). And as Stephen Knight points out in *Form and Ideology in Crime Fiction,* if the world were as perfectly ordered as Holmes's representation of it, then there would be no need for heroic action (75). There must be a world outside the rational for Holmes to be a hero. While this irrational world may be represented by silent women in some of the Holmes stories, there is another large group of these stories whose atmosphere is dominated by the irrational and whose characters are predominantly female. That world is the Gothic. I want to suggest that both the Gothic elements and the female clients in these stories play an important role in establishing the rational detective as a powerful, patriarchal hero.

In addition to their Gothic atmosphere and their female victims, these stories share the same basic plot: they revolve around the struggle of an older man (men) to wrest an inheritance away from a young woman. In "The Solitary Cyclist," Violet Smith is left a large sum of money by her uncle in South Africa. Two cohorts of her uncle come to England in an attempt to marry her before she can learn of that inheritance. In "The Speckled Band," Grimsby Roylott kills one of his stepdaughters, Julia Stoner, and attempts to kill the other, Helen Stoner, so that their money (inherited from their mother) will not leave his control when they marry. And, in "The Copper Beeches," Jephro Rucastle keeps his daughter Alice locked up on his country estate so that she cannot marry and give her money (again inherited from her mother) to her husband. In these three stories, Doyle was capitalizing on a recent change in the law. The Women's Property Acts of 1870-82 allowed women both to own and inherit property independently of their fathers or husbands. In defending the daughter's rights against the father (or in "The Solitary Cyclist," the woman's rights against her suitors), Holmes seems to be battling an older order's reactionary and regressive attempt to return to an era in which male control of property could not be questioned.

Claire Kahane's article, "The Gothic Mirror," shows how the Gothic genre also centers on the problem of female inheritance. Kahane gives a feminist psychoanalytic reading of the Gothic that places "the spectral presence of a dead-undead mother . . . a ghost signifying the problematics of femininity" at the center of the Gothic (336). In the Gothic, the reader reexperiences the infant's relationship with the mother's body, which is "awesome and powerful . . . our habitat and our prison" (Kahane 336-37). The infant's attachment to the mother's body and the consequent unformed sense of self is repeated in the Gothic themes of imprisonment and the Doppelgänger. This attachment is, however, more problematic for female than for male children. The male child's physical difference from his mother facilitates the formation of a separate identity. But the female child inherits her mother's body—a physical similarity that interferes with separation. At the mirror stage, the male child may see himself as both self and other, but the female child also sees herself as both self and mother. The Gothic is a genre that allows women to relive the complexities of this similarity/difference (Kahane 334-51).

While Kahane emphasizes the psychological meaning of the Gothic, I want to shift that emphasis to a more politically charged reading. To be identified with the mother is not only psychologically threatening, but also socially threatening because it means being identified with the oppressed gender. Being trapped in the Gothic house is, then, both a

fear of being trapped in the mother's body, and a fear of being trapped in the mother's role. This fear is even more clear-cut in the Holmes stories than in other Gothic narratives since most of the women (Helen Stoner, Alice Rucastle, Violet Smith) are just about to be married. The fantasy of being "the angel in the house" becomes the nightmare of being a prisoner in the house. Significantly, though, it is not these women's fiancés who keep them locked up, but their fathers (or father figures). It is attachment to fathers, and not to husbands, that is portrayed as imprisoning these women in the domestic sphere.

The socio-symbolic message of both the Gothic atmosphere and the plot elements (which rely so heavily on The Women's Property Acts) is that oppression of women belongs to the past generation, not the present. Holmes, as the representative of a new, rational order, is required to step into this Gothic world of the past and free these women from that oppression.

The older social order is represented by the villains who oppose Holmes. Grimsby Roylott is descended from Saxon nobility, and his last name associates him with royalty. Jephro Rucastle's name has both feudal and Gothic associations—he is the owner of the rueful castle. Carruthers and Woodley, the two villains of "The Solitary Cyclist," have spent their lives in South Africa, and have returned with an anachronistic sense of English law. They believe, for example, that it is possible to force a woman to go through with a marriage against her will, and that such a marriage will be legally binding. Holmes points out to them that such a marriage is "no marriage, but . . . a very serious felony" (Doyle 741).

These villains' power is physical, as opposed to Holmes's power of rational deduction. Grimsby Roylott and Jephro Rucastle are massive men. Roylott fills both the height and width of Holmes's doorway, while Rucastle is "a prodigiously stout man with a very smiling face and a great heavy chin which rolled down in fold upon fold over his throat . . ." (432). The appearance of Carruthers in "The Solitary Cyclist" is made ominous by the "coal-black beard" that he uses to disguise his features (738); his partner, Woodley, the more physically threatening of the two men, is "hideously strong" (729). The effect of this physical power is displayed on the victims' bodies. Helen Stoner's hair has turned prematurely gray while she has suffered under her stepfather's tyrannical rule, and his hand has left "Five little livid spots . . . printed upon the white wrist," which Holmes uncovers (354). Jephro Rucastle's daughter, Alice, loses her hair in a fit of brain fever brought on by her father's attempt to get her to sign over her inheritance. Violet Hunter, Holmes's client in "The Copper Beeches," is hired by Rucastle as an unwitting stand-in for Alice in a plot to deceive Alice's fiancé. As

part of that plot, Violet is ordered to cut her hair, much against her will, and it is, in fact, this odd stipulation of her contract that leads her to seek out Holmes's advice about accepting the position as governess with the Rucastles. And finally, Violet Smith, "The Solitary Cyclist," is twice physically attacked by Woodley: the first time he "made odious love" to her (729); the second time he abducts her on a lonely road in what, at first, seems to be an attempted rape. He then binds and gags her in preparation for the real crime—a forced wedding service in which he is the groom.

As is apparent in the last example, physical terror in these stories has strongly sexual overtones. Perhaps the most obvious example of underlying sexual tension is Grimsby Roylott's method of killing his stepdaughter Julia. He kills Julia Stoner (and attempts to kill Helen) by putting a hole in her bedroom wall through which he sends a poisonous adder. He also has her bed "clamped to the floor" so that she cannot avoid the adder's sting. This last act of Roylott's is completely gratuitous to the accomplishment of the crime. Why would Julia Stoner decide to move her bed? She would have to suspect the crime, and if she did, would certainly take greater precautions. However, the clamped bed is emphasized by Holmes as the most revealing clue:

> "Did you observe anything very peculiar about that bed?"
> "No."
> "It was clamped to the floor. Did you ever see a bed fastened like that before?"
> "I cannot say that I have."
> "The lady could not move her bed. It must always be in the same relative position to the ventilator and to the rope—or so we may call it, since it was clearly never meant for a bell-pull."
> "Holmes," I cried, "I seem to see dimly what you are hinting at. We are only just in time to prevent some subtle and horrible crime." (Doyle 364)

The emphasis on the clamped bed, which is wholly unnecessary to the crime, brings out a metaphoric relation between Julia Stoner and her bed. By clamping her bed to the floor, Roylott keeps Julia Stoner's body in the correct position for his striking serpent; the clamped bed acts to reinforce an already strong suggestion of incestuous rape.

Having the same body as her twin sister Julia, Helen seems destined to share her fate. But through Holmes's intervention her stepfather's snake is turned back on him, killing him, and freeing her to marry. Opposed to the villains' phallic domination over the female

body, Holmes's mastery over the physical world through rational knowledge appears to be much less gender restrictive. The power to be articulate and observant is not biologically determined, as is apparent in the "clearness and composure" ("The Solitary Cyclist" [Doyle 729]) with which Holmes's female clients make their statements. A more fully articulated version of the ideology of these stories is, then, that by allying themselves to this new world of rationality, women can detach themselves from the mother's female body and her oppressed role, thereby overcoming the threat of an older, patriarchal domination. By fully participating in the Holmesian discourse, Holmes's clients can form their own identities and become subjects who make free choices about marriage, rather than being passive participants in forced marriages. These modern marriages will allow women to escape from the anachronistic society of their fathers in which women were treated as physical property, and marriage was based on financial, rather than romantic, considerations.

But is Holmes's power really any less patriarchal than that of the villains of these stories? There does not, initially, seem to be a strong gendering of the rational deductive power that Holmes represents; however, the main emphasis on gender in these stories is not on rational power, but on physical power. Though the beginnings of each story focus on Holmes's ability to make brilliant deductions, those deductive powers do not bring the stories to a close. Instead, Holmes takes over the Gothic villain's role as physically dominant male while the villain steps into the physically dominated female role: the relation of father to daughter is replaced by the relation of Holmes to father. Again, this is especially evident in "The Speckled Band." At the beginning of the story Helen Stoner is described as a "hunted animal" (Doyle 347), while her stepfather, Grimsby Roylott, looks like "a fierce old bird of prey" (356). Roylott quickly becomes the hunted, though, in Holmes's warning that "he may find that there is someone more cunning than himself upon his track" (359). In their only face-to-face meeting, Roylott calls Holmes "the meddler" and "the busybody" (356). In this terminology, detecting is rendered as a feminized, old-ladyish profession. However, Holmes turns this language back on Roylott, labeling him "this beauty" (1: 357)—a term that not only feminizes him, but draws attention to the homoerotics of the male detective's pursuit of the villainous male "beauty."

The homoerotics of this encounter is further emphasized in the threats that each man makes to the other. Roylott warns Holmes against his embrace: bending a poker from Holmes's fireplace, he warns, "See that you keep yourself out of my grip" (357). Holmes, returning grip for grip, straightens the poker, saying, "if he had

remained I might have shown him that my grip was not much more feeble than his own" (357). Not only does Holmes show himself to be more powerful, since it would take more strength to straighten than to bend a poker, but he also shows himself to be more masculine, since he straightens the poker back to an erect position.

These overtones are most noticeable in the image of the striking serpent. Holmes describes Roylott as a man who "strikes even deeper" than the criminals Palmer and Pritchard, but then goes on to say that he and Watson "shall be able to strike deeper still" (364). And indeed Holmes is able to strike Roylott deeply using Roylott's own phallic weapon. Holmes is hiding in Julia Stoner's room when Roylott attempts to kill Helen by again forcing his snake through the bedroom wall. As the adder descends, Holmes beats it with his bamboo cane (phallus opposing phallus). This forces the adder to return through the hole into Roylott's room where it kills Roylott. The struggle between Roylott and Holmes becomes a struggle to see which one will be forced to play Julia Stoner's role, which one will be the passive recipient of the other's strike, and in this homoerotic struggle Holmes is the victor.

As the text focuses on the male-male conflict, the female client fades into the background. Once Grimsby Roylott is dead, Watson seems in a hurry to close the narrative, and Helen Stoner is only an impediment to that closure: "It is not necessary that I should prolong a narrative which has already run to too great a length by telling how we broke the sad news to the terrified girl . . ." (367). Helen Stoner has served her function in the text, which is to bring about the duel between Holmes and her stepfather in which her stepfather's power is passed down to Holmes. So what begins as a story about female inheritance of property becomes a story of male inheritance of power In both "The Speckled Band" and "The Copper Beeches," madness is inherent in the male line of the family. Holmes is, then, the needed stepson who inherits male power without inheriting the male weakness of madness.

As power is transferred from father to son, the women of the stories are transferred from father to husband; Holmes facilitates the correct exchange of women. He overcomes the father's incestuous control of Alice Rucastle and Helen Stoner, and he delivers Helen Stoner and Violet Smith to their prospective husbands. Gayle Rubin's article on the incest taboo, "The Traffic in Women," analyzes the exchange of women in society at large—an analysis that can be applied to the exchange of women in these stories:

> In the cycle of exchange . . . the phallus passes through the medium of women from one man to another. the phallus

> is more than a feature which distinguishes the sexes. . . . It is an expression of the transmission of male dominance. (192)

Women in the Holmes stories, like the women Rubin describes, are a conduit for male power. As the object of sexual dominance, they are necessary to release that power. But they do not acquire power themselves; it is, instead, passed on to Holmes.

Women are, in fact, not merely the catalyst for sexual dominance; they are pictured as the very source of sexuality, as is apparent when Holmes and Watson join Grimsby Roylott in confusing Julia Stoner's body with her bed. As the source of sexuality, the women must be recontained in marriage (Violet Smith, Alice Rucastle, Helen Stoner), or spinsterhood (Violet Hunter). For while the sensational and sexual elements of these Gothic stories are necessary to bring Holmes's power into play, these elements must, in the end, be brought under control.

Holmes's relation to the women and the Gothic elements of these stories can perhaps best be summarized by the opening of "The Copper Beeches." At the beginning of this story, Holmes berates Watson for filling his stories with "color and life" (Doyle 430), making them too "sensational" (Doyle 429, 431). Shortly afterward, though, Holmes bemoans the lack of criminal enterprise, and states that his cases are becoming increasingly "trivial": "As to my own little practice, it seems to be degenerating into an agency for recovering lost lead pencils, and giving advice to young ladies from boarding schools" (431).

Without the Gothic, sensational elements of these stories, Holmes's cases will be trivial: "recovering lost lead pencils, and giving advice to young ladies from boarding schools." Note that the "trivial" is associated either with the feminine, or is pictured as loss of masculinity and loss of discourse (lost lead pencils). To have trivial cases would feminize and emasculate Holmes, removing him from the hero's empowered position as controller of discourse. Beyond the heroic is the mundane, the trivial, to which the powerless figures of society, women chief among them, are consigned. Holmes requires the sensational and the Gothic in order to keep him out of this feminine, marginal area.

However, as noted above, the sensational, Gothic world is also a feminine, marginal area. These women are registers of the very "color and life" that Holmes objects to as sensationalizing elements. The first names of Violet Hunter and Violet Smith link them to sensational or "purple" prose.[1] Both Violet Hunter and Alice Rucastle have beautiful manes of chestnut hair, which must be shorn under Jephro Rucastle's oppressive rule. And Violet is made to wear an "electric-blue" dress as part of her impersonation of Alice. The colorfulness of the women is

directly linked to their "life"—their independence and energy. The Violets are both described as vital women: Violet Hunter has "a bright, quick face, freckled like a plover's egg, and with the brisk manner of a woman who has had her own way to make in the world" (Doyle 432), while Violet Smith is "an ardent bicyclist . . . full of energy" (727). Helen Stoner and Jephro Rucastle's second wife are less lively women, and their lack of energy is depicted in their fading, or lost color. In Helen Stoner's case, there is an implicit connection between her stepfather's terrorizing domination and her loss of color: both she and her twin sister, before her death, go prematurely gray. In the case of Jephro Rucastle that connection becomes more explicit. His wife's devotion to him is juxtaposed with her lack of color:

> Mrs. Rucastle seemed to me to be colourless in mind as well as in feature. She impressed me neither favourably nor the reverse. She was a nonentity. It was easy to see that she was passionately devoted to her husband and her little son. Her light gray eyes wandered continually from one to the other, noting every little want and forestalling it if possible. (440)

Though it is women who are colorful, that color, like the color of Violet Hunter's hair and dress, is put to use by men, and, after a time, that color, that sexual energy and independence, is drained away under male domination.

Holmes himself cannot be sensational or colorful; to be sensational would remove him from the rational world. But Holmes does need the sensations that his female clients provide in order to make his cases exciting. His clients import these elements of a world beyond the rational, a world in need of Holmes's power to return it to rational order and control. Once controlled, Holmes's female clients also lose their color. Violet Smith goes from being an energetic and "spirited" woman, to a hysterical, frightened girl. Helen Stoner fades into marriage, and then death. And, finally, Violet Hunter goes from being an enticing match for Holmes's deductive powers to becoming the spinsterish head of a young ladies' boarding school.

The Gothic genre in these stories makes male domination seem part of some older, aristocratic order that is overcome in the new rational world represented by Holmes. But Holmes, like the Gothic villains, uses and controls his colorful female clients. They are marginalized outside of the heroic/rational discourse into the extremes of triviality and sensation. These marginal areas border the world of heroism and rationality, allowing both to exist at the same time. They serve to overcome the contradiction inherent in Holmes's merger of

heroism and rationality. Holmes acquires his heroic power by facilitating the exchange of these women, both from father to husband, and from the sensational, Gothic world, to the trivial world of bourgeois marriage or spinsterhood. Just as the older order is based upon the representation of women as physical property, Holmes's system relies upon the representation of women as physical properties—the colorful and sensational—in order for Holmes to play the hero; but that physical stimulus must be recontained by the trivial in order to return to a well-ordered rational world.

NOTE

[1]The *OED* lists the phrase "purple-patch," applied to a lurid passage in literature as coming to prominence in the late nineteenth century.

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